

Sunflower

From a small, stripy seed, a mighty plant grows. The sunflower shoots up to the sky, and after only a couple of months it can be taller than five adult humans stood on each other's shoulders! Its golden petals form a huge ring around a dark centre. This disc holds masses of smaller flowers – each of which later become a seed.

Sunflowers grow wild in the grasslands of the USA and Mexico. These are shorter and have smaller flower heads than garden sunflowers. Several thousand years ago, Native American people began to farm sunflowers for their seeds, which are tasty and can be crushed into cooking oil. Now gardeners try to grow the tallest plants with the biggest flowers.

Sunflower buds turn to face the Sun throughout the day. The open flowers face to the east.

